

Katie Pearce

August 3, 2026

Utah State Charter School Board
250 East 500 South
P.O. Box 144200
Salt Lake City, UT 84114

RE: Concerns Regarding Leadership and Governance at Vista School, Ivins, UT

Executive Summary

- Since the current Director's arrival roughly three years ago, Vista School has experienced staff turnover well beyond normal levels, including the departure of the entire math department and multiple long-tenured office staff.
- A findings report from the Director's prior school district documented a pattern of dismissive and demeaning treatment of employees — a pattern that appears to be repeating at Vista.
- Teachers report receiving annual contracts only on the last day of the school year, after the local hiring fair, limiting their ability to seek other employment.
- Staff who are demoted and choose to resign rather than accept the demotion are characterized publicly as having resigned voluntarily.
- The Director does not appear to take accountability for negative outcomes while taking credit for the school's successes.
- A sweeping curriculum change was implemented last year without adequate support for teachers, despite repeated requests.
- Parent and community access to the school has been significantly restricted, including denial of entry to a school assembly.
- Vista's governance structure no longer allows parents to vote for school board members; members are now appointed by a committee that includes the Director.
- The Director and COO are reportedly compensated well above comparable positions in Southern Utah, while the school struggles to offer competitive pay to teachers and staff.
- I am requesting that the Board investigate these concerns and conduct a financial audit of executive compensation relative to staff pay and the school's overall budget.

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Dear Members of the Utah State Charter School Board,

I am writing as a parent of two daughters enrolled at Vista School in Ivins, Utah, to share concerns about the direction the school has taken under its current administration. My oldest daughter began at Vista in Kindergarten in 2019 and is entering 7th grade this fall; my younger daughter started at Vista in Kindergarten in 2022 as well and entering 4th grade this fall. Several members of our extended family have also chosen to enroll their children at Vista because of the reputation and opportunities the school has historically offered.

We chose Vista because of the well-rounded educational experience it promised — the chance for our children to explore different areas of interest that would support both their academic growth and leadership development. For years, that promise was reflected in the relationships we built with dedicated teachers, paraprofessionals, and staff who clearly cared about our children's success.

Over the past three years, through two administration changes, that experience has changed significantly. I am writing to raise the following specific concerns:

Staff Turnover. We have watched excellent, experienced teachers leave the school. After the first year of the current administration, the entire math department departed. Office staff who invested significant time and effort supporting our children and families have also left suddenly. This level of turnover is, in our view, a signal that something in the school's internal culture needs attention.

Curriculum Change Without Support. Last year, a sweeping curriculum change was implemented. Teachers have asked administration for help and support in adapting to it, but by our understanding, that support has not been provided.

A Documented Pattern from the Director's Prior District. I have reviewed a findings report from the school district where our current Director previously worked, prior to his departure from that position. That report documented a pattern of dismissive treatment of employees, demeaning remarks directed at staff, and open disparagement of those who disagreed with him. It also described the removal of a well-regarded principal, with the stated reasoning that a principal

should not be more popular than the superintendent. Since this Director's arrival at Vista, I have observed what appears to be the same pattern play out here: integral employees and teachers have left or been let go at a rate that goes well beyond normal turnover.

Contract Timing. Teachers have not received their annual contracts until the last day of the school year — well after the local school district's hiring fair has already taken place. This timing makes it significantly harder for any teacher who might want or need to leave Vista to find another teaching position, effectively limiting their options regardless of their reasons for wanting to move on.

Demotions Framed as Resignations. I understand that some staff have been demoted, and when they declined the demotion and resigned as a result, the departure was characterized by administration as the employee's own choice to resign rather than as a consequence of the demotion itself. This framing obscures what is, in substance, being pushed out.

Lack of Accountability. By multiple accounts, the Director does not take responsibility for outcomes that reflect poorly on his leadership, while taking credit for the school's successes. This pattern makes it very difficult for staff or parents to raise concerns, since there is no apparent mechanism by which problems are acknowledged or addressed at the top.

Erosion of Trust and Communication. There is a palpable sense of angst and fear among teachers, staff, and parents. Concerns raised by parents and staff do not feel heard. What was once a genuine sense of teamwork and partnership between families, staff, and leadership no longer exists.

Reduced Parent and Community Access. Parent volunteers, who undergo background checks, now have significantly reduced access to the school. I was personally turned away when I attempted to attend a school assembly. These changes have made it harder for parents to stay engaged and involved in our children's education.

Governance Structure. Parents no longer vote for school board members; instead, board members are appointed by a committee that includes the school director. This shift removes a meaningful layer of parent voice and accountability from the school's governance.

Executive Compensation. I understand that the Director and the COO are both compensated at levels significantly above what is typical for comparable positions at other schools in Southern Utah, while the school has struggled to offer competitive pay increases to teachers and other staff. Given the staff turnover and support issues described above, I believe a financial audit examining executive compensation relative to overall staff pay and the school's budget is warranted.

Individually, some of these issues might be explained away. Together, they paint a picture of a school culture that has moved away from transparency, collaboration, and community

involvement — the very qualities that made Vista a place our family and extended family chose, repeatedly, over other options.

Given that a prior district's own findings documented this pattern of behavior before the Director came to Vista, I do not believe what our community is experiencing is a coincidence or a series of unrelated personnel decisions. I am asking the Board to look closely into the rate and manner of staff departures at Vista, the timing of teacher contract issuance, how demotions and resulting resignations are being characterized to staff and the community, and the governance structure that removed parent voting rights for board members. I am also formally requesting a financial audit of Vista School, with particular attention to executive compensation for the Director and COO relative to comparable positions in Southern Utah and relative to the pay and resources available to teachers and staff. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss these concerns further, and to share the prior district's report if that would be useful to the Board's review. I hope the Board will consider whether Vista's current leadership and governance practices remain consistent with the standards expected of Utah charter schools.

Thank you for your time and attention to this matter.

Sincerely,

Katie Pearce, MSN, CNM, MBA
Parent of Vista School students